How to Raise the Conversation You've Been Putting Off About Your Husband's Care

One conversation, one subject, and a way to write down how each person sees it.

There's a conversation with your daughter you keep not having. You know what it's about. You don't know how to begin.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: get the subject said out loud, and write down how each person sees it. It isn't for settling it.

Who should be there, and when

Start with the person the subject is really with. If that's your daughter, it can be the two of you at the kitchen table. The whole family doesn't have to be in the room for a first conversation.

Think about your husband's place in it too. The Family Caregiver Alliance points out that the person being cared for usually doesn't want to be left out of family events, and that his preferences for care must be considered. If he won't be in the room, ask him beforehand what he'd want said. [1]

Pick an ordinary day. The National Institute on Aging says a conversation about sharing care is most productive when there is not an emergency, and that is where you are. [2]

How to open

Say the subject in one or two plain sentences, built around what your husband needs and not around what anyone did or didn't do. Then ask a question and wait for the answer.

Keep it to the one subject, and speak for yourself. The Family Caregiver Alliance says a narrow focus helps a family meeting, and suggests “I need…” in place of “You should…” [1]

- “I'd like to talk about how we look after Dad. Nothing has happened. I'd like to talk about it on a quiet day.”
- “I wrote down what I do for him in a week. I need you to look at it with me and tell me what you see.”
- Say what the conversation is for: hearing how each of you sees one subject. Say what it isn't for: deciding who was right, or changing everything today.

Questions to ask

Ask your husband

1. How do you feel things are going, day to day?

2. What would you want us to keep in mind while we talk about this?

Ask each other

1. What do you see getting harder, for me and for you?

2. Which tasks has each of us assumed the other was handling?

3. What do you need made clearer, and what do you need a hand with?

4. Where do we see this differently?

5. Is there a disagreement we should talk through now, while there's time?

6. What haven't we talked about that we should?

How to write down what was said

Write each person's account in their own words, and keep it separate from everyone else's. Where two of you see it differently, write both and don't settle it. A page with two versions on it is a finished page.

THE CONCERN, IN THEIR WORDS	WHO SAID IT	AN EXAMPLE THEY GAVE	SEEN DIFFERENTLY BY
“I do his pills, his rides and the pharmacy now. A year ago I did none of them.”	Me	Four appointments this month	Our daughter thought the pharmacy delivered
“I'd do more if I knew what needed doing. Nobody tells me.”	Our son	Heard about the eye appointment afterward	

What not to decide yet

These take a fuller picture than one conversation gives, and some of them take a professional who has met him. Leave them open.

- Who was right.
- Whether the arrangement is working.
- Whether your husband needs more help, or anything about where he lives.

- Anything about his health or his medications.

What you can decide today

Whatever wasn't settled goes on an open list for next time. One conversation isn't expected to finish it.

- Who will write up the notes and send them to everyone who was there.
- Who will find out each thing nobody knew the answer to.
- When you'll talk again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't settle a disagreement, take anyone's side, or tell you what a professional would say. It gets one subject said out loud and onto a page, with each person's view left the way they gave it.

Ready for the next step?

One subject is out in the open now, with each person's view written down. The care interview takes that page further: it goes through your husband's situation and the help around him area by area, and turns it into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
2. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities